

Concept, understanding and evolution of Society



Society

What is Society?

- The word 'Society' comes from a Latin word 'socius' which means 'companionship or friendship'.
- Society refers to a **group of people who share a distinct culture** and live in a specific **geographic area**. For say, the American Society.
- A long-standing group of people from a specific geographic boundary sharing cultural aspects such as language, dress, norms of behavior and artistic forms.

Definition of society

How society is defined?

- According to sociologist **Anthony Giddens**, "Society is a group of **people** who live in a **particular territory**, are subject to a common system of **political authority**, and are aware of having a **distinct identity from other groups**." 

- Morris Ginsberg** defines society as a **collection of individuals** united by certain **relations** or **mode of behavior** which mark them off from others who do not enter into these relations or who differ from them in behavior. 

Fundamental elements of society

Fundamental Elements of Society:

a. Likeness:

- Without a sense of being "alike," there can be no recognition of a shared identity or community.
 - It allows for mutual understanding and cooperation.
- Example:** Shared language, customs, values, and beliefs.

b. Difference:

- While likeness provides the foundation, difference creates the need for social interaction.
- If everyone was exactly the same, there would be no specialization, exchange, or complex relationships.

Example: The division of labor—hunters, farmers, artisans—depends on people having different skills and roles.



Fundamental elements of society

c. Inter-dependence:

- Society is based on cooperation. People rely on each other for survival and well-being.
 - This creates a complex system of mutual obligations and support.
- Example:** A modern city dweller depends on farmers for food, engineers for infrastructure, and doctors for healthcare.



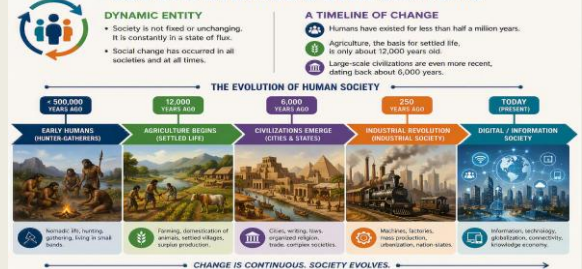
d. Multiplicity of relationships:

- Society is not one single relationship but a vast, complex web of them.
- These can be hundreds or thousands of types: familial, economic, political, religious, friendly, professional, etc.
- This immense network of connections is what makes social life rich and dynamic.



Nature of society

SOCIETY: DYNAMIC & EVER-CHANGING



Evolution

The Concept of "Evolution"

General Definition of Evolution:

- The term "evolution" represents the process of gradual development.
- It describes how, over time, simple things become more complex and differentiated.

Evolution in a Social Context:

- In anthropology, social evolution is the theory that all societies progress through a series of stages from "simple" to "complex."



Evolution

The Founders of 19th-Century Evolutionism

The "Fathers" of the Theory:

- The two leading evolutionists are generally considered to be the founders of 19th-century social evolutionism.

1. Sir Edward Burnett Tylor (British):

- Published his famous work, *Primitive Culture*, in 1871.
- Known for his focus on the evolution of religion and culture from "primitive" to "civilized."

2. Lewis Henry Morgan (American):

- Published his major work, *Ancient Society*, in 1877.
- Provided the most detailed exposition of the three-stage model of social development.

Evolution

Three Stages of Evolution (Tylor & Morgan):

E.B. Tylor's Core Idea:

- Society's evolution is *unidirectional*. This means all societies go through the same stages in the same order.

Lewis Henry Morgan's Expansion:

- He gave a detailed exposition of this model, dividing the first two stages further.

The three main stages are:

Stage 1. **Savagery** (Lower, Middle, Upper)

Stage 2. **Barbarism** (Lower, Middle, Upper)

Stage 3. **Civilization** (no sub-divisions)

Evolution

Stage 1 - Lower Savagery (The Beginning):

Time period: Paleolithic Era, ca. 2 million - 12,000 years ago)

The Dawn of Humanity:

- The period *before* the use of fire.
- People lived in their original habitat—tropical or subtropical forests—and were partially tree-dwellers.

Key Characteristics:

- **Subsistence:** Simple food collection. People gathered fruits, nuts, and roots.
- **Social Organization:** Lived in promiscuous bands. **Indiscriminate mating** was practiced.
- **Economic System:** Primitive communism (shared resources).
- **Major Achievement:** The development of **articulate speech**.



Evolution

Stage 1 - Middle Savagery (The Great Leap Forward)

Time: Paleolithic Era

The Turning Point:

- Begins with the **use of fire** and the **utilization of fish** for food (including crabs, mussels, etc.).
- These two are complementary, as fish only becomes edible with fire.

Impact on Society:

- **New Independence:** Human beings became less dependent on specific climates and locations. They could move to new territories.
- **New Foods:** Discovered new kinds of food, like roots and tubers, which could be baked in hot ashes.
- **A Dark Reality:** Due to continual uncertainty of food supplies, **cannibalism** is believed to have arisen and persisted for a long time.

Modern Example: The Australian aborigines and many Polynesians were thought to be in this stage.



Evolution

Stage 1 - Upper Savagery (The Age of Invention)

Time: Upper Savagery (Paleolithic Era)

Key Innovations:

- The introduction of the **bow and arrow**.
- This was a major advancement in hunting technology.

Settlement and Crafts:

- People began to settle in **villages**.
- Development of wooden vessels and utensils.
- Finger-weaving (without looms).
- Plaited baskets.
- The creation of sharpened (neolithic) stone tools.

Modern Example: The Indians of northwest America were considered to be in this stage.



Evolution

Stage 2 - Lower Barbarism (The Neolithic Revolution)

Time period: Neolithic Era, ca. 12,000 years ago



The Agricultural Revolution:

- Begins with **plant domestication**. This is the single most important event in human history.
- The cultivation of plants led to a stable food supply.
- The **invention of pottery** allowed for the storage and cooking of food.
- **Interesting Fact:** Pottery likely originated from covering baskets with clay to make them fireproof.

Social Structures:

- The clan system became **matrilineal** (descent traced through the mother).
- Clan **exogamy** (marrying outside the clan) was practiced.
- Communal ownership of property.

Evolution

Stage 2 - Middle Barbarism (The Age of Herding)

Animal Domestication:

- The domestication of animals provided a new and reliable source of food (milk, meat).
- This allowed for the pastoral lifestyle.



Agricultural Developments:

- Some tribes (e.g., those east of the Mississippi) practiced horticulture, growing maize, gourds, and melons.

Social Changes:

- **Cannibalism ended** as food supplies became more stable.
- The clan system became **patrilineal** (descent traced through the father).
- A shift towards **individual ownership** of property.
- **Polygamy** emerged as a practice.

Evolution

Stage 2 - Upper Barbarism (The Age of Metal)

The Use of Metals:

- The hallmark of this stage is the use of metal, eventually leading to a **Bronze Age** and then an **Iron Age**.
- Neolithic (stone-based) cultures added the use of metal for tools and weapons.
- This represented a huge leap forward in technology, warfare, and agriculture.



Evolution

Stage 3 - Civilization (The Modern Era)

Time period: ca. 5000 years ago to Present.



The Culmination of Evolution:

- According to the 19th-century theorists, civilization represents the highest, most advanced stage of human development.

Hallmarks of Civilization:

- **Intensive agriculture** (surplus food production).
- **Industrialization** (large-scale manufacturing).
- **Capitalism** (a market economy).
- **Social stratification** (clear class or caste distinctions).
- The **political state** (organized government with laws and a monopoly on force).
- **Full-time occupational specialists** (people dedicated to specific trades, arts, or sciences)

Thank you all
